

WHY CRYPTO?

Sometimes the word *crypto* makes people shudder, perhaps because they associate it with illicit activity, but that's a mental bias that is important to overcome. Crypto is simply a tip of the hat to and a shortening of the key technology underlying these systems: cryptography. As discussed in [Chapter 2](#), cryptography is the science of securely transmitting data so that only intended recipients can make use of it. Cryptography is used to ensure that cryptoassets are transferred to the intended recipients securely. Given our digital world and the increasing prevalence of hacks, the secure transmission of resources is paramount, and cryptoassets have such security in spades.

THE EVER-EVOLVING NATURE OF CURRENCIES

The pursuit of a decentralized, private, and digital currency predates bitcoin by decades. Bitcoin and its digital siblings are just part of a broader evolution of currencies that has taken place over centuries. At their inception, currencies were a solution to ease the impreciseness of barter trade, and for centuries metal coins with material value served as the currencies of choice. Fiat currency was an innovation beyond metal coins, as it was much easier to transport, but the entirety of its value relied upon the government's stamp of approval